rode Engine No. 738 on its maiden trip, along with the driver and two attendants, to prove the safety of the railway and the capability of the engine. As the engine reached Matheran, in a surge of joy and excitement, Peerbhoy's coat got stuck in the engine and was torn.

Excited, Peerbhoy showered money on the gathered crowd and workers to celebrate the safe arrival of the train in Matheran. When the news was conveyed to his father Adamjee Peerbhoy K.T., he broke down in tears. [81]

WHEN A HERD OF WILD ELEPHANTS STOPPED THE TRAIN

Small lines and trains were always prone to threats from wildlife. A souvenir published by the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway Company Limited in 1921 documents how herds of elephants stopped the movement of trains and how the jungles near Sukna (13 km from Siliguri), which is now the gateway to the 159 sq km of reserve forest Mahananda Wildlife Sanctuary, [82] were once the haunt of leopards .

Battles of a Popular Narrow Gauge Train

For starters, the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway, or simply the DHR, is known far and wide. Along with the Nilgiri Mountain Railway and the Kalka–Shimla Railway (KSR), it is in the UNESCO heritage list of India's Mountain Railways. With a 2-foot gauge and about 78 km long, the line was built between 1879 and 1881 from New Jalpaiguri to Darjeeling.

Originally called the 'Steam Tramway' and first proposed in 1878 by Franklin Prestage, an agent of Eastern Bengal Railway Company, it was constructed by Gillanders Arbuthnot & Co. The stretch from Siliguri to Kurseong was opened on 23 August 1880, while the official opening of the line up to Darjeeling was on 4 July 1881. This railway faced constant threats and disruptions from wildlife. Here are some excerpts:

At the ninth mile from Sukna, the track passes through the fine sal and toon forest. Not many years ago a herd of wild elephants disrupted the passage of the train through this forest and the driver had perforce to cut back into Sukna and await the departure of the unwelcome marauders. These lower forests form cover for tigers, leopards, wild buffalo, deer, hogs and wolves, as well as for a host of small animals such as monkeys and wild cats. Rhinoceri are found in the Teesta and other rivers, while the jungle covers are replete with jungle-fowl, woodcock and pigeons of various sorts .

Creepers are seen pendant from the trees, and ferns and bamboo grass cover the banks. Giant bamboos wave their feathery crests above. The view opens out to the south and the wooded plains of the Terai are seen below. The traveller may be surprised to see how rapidly he has already risen from the plains. The railway track now winds in and out of the